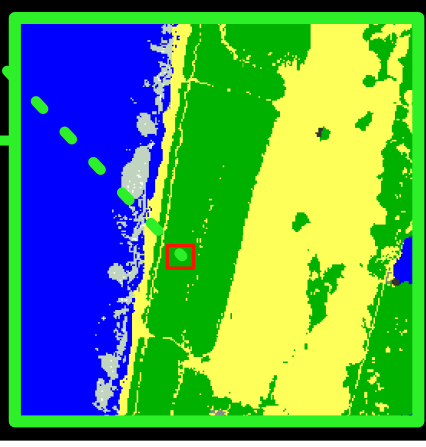
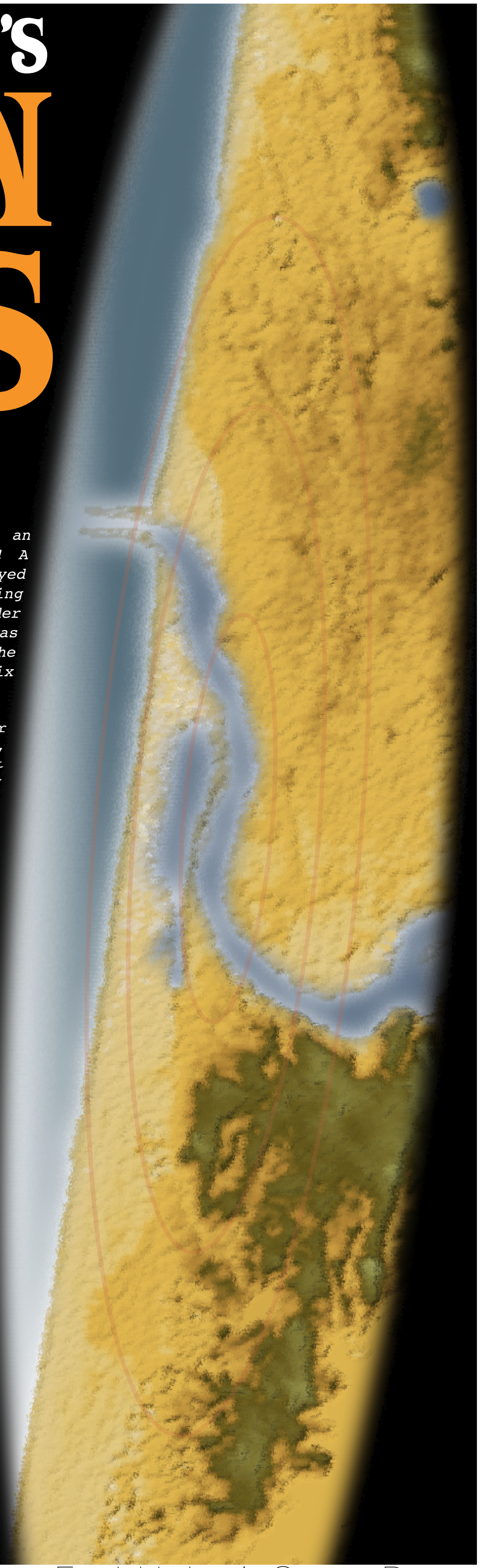
FRANK HERBERT'S OREGON DUNES

Planet: Earth [Terra]
Year: 1957
Location: Oregon, United States
Planetary Coordinates: 43.724167, -124.1775

"The thing the ecologically illiterate don't realize about an ecosystem," Kynes said, "is that it's a system. A system! A system maintains a certain fluid stability that can be destroyed by a misstep in just one niche. A system has order, a flowing from point to point. If something dams that flow, order collapses. The untrained might miss that collapse until it was too late. That's why the highest function of ecology is the understanding of consequences." — Frank Herbert, Dune, Appendix I: The Ecology of Dune

When Frank Herbert glimpsed the Oregon Dunes from a passenger plane in 1957, he beheld a vast arid expanse of sand, interspersed with emerging patches of green, a stark contrast to the surrounding wasteland. These verdant areas, tinged by human terraforming efforts, might well have sparked the concept of Arrakis and the ideology of its Fremen denizens in Herbert's mind. He observed the triumphs of the US Department of Agriculture in halting the drift of "the moving sands" onto adjacent railways, roads, and residences, hailing it as an "unsung victory in the fight of men against dunes" (Herbert et al., 2005; de Freitas, 2022). However, much like the tradgey of Muad'Dib, this victory bore unintended consequnce. The introduced 'Ammophila Arenaria' has since led to widespread ecological disturbances. Unchecked, it has reduced the once vast sandy habitats, essential for the survival of native species like the western snowy plover and the Siuslaw hairy-necked tiger beetle, and inadvertently provided shelter for predators such as coyotes (Oregon Dunes Restoration Collaborative, 2024). The narrative of the Oregon Dunes, much like Herbert's celebrated novel, unveils the intricate and unforeseen outcomes of well-meaning interventions, and highlights the myriad challenges conservation efforts face in balancing ecological, legal, and social factors.

Species: Ammophila arenaria
Common Names: Marram Grass, European Beachgrass
Family: Poaceae (Grasses)



Year: 2023
Ammophila arenaria thrives.